

THE SECOND GLASS

Written by

Written by

James & Maya – a oner

Working title. One continuous shot, no cuts.
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FADE IN:

EXT. SUBURBAN HOUSE - NIGHT

Black. Then rooftops – the flat blue dark of a cul-de-sac asleep.

The camera hangs high above one house. A single downstairs window burns gold against all that blue.

It begins to descend. Not a fall. A glide. It snakes down through the cold, unhurried, tilting toward the light the way a thing comes home.

Closer. The window. The sill. It slips through the gap where the pane sits open an inch –

INT. HOUSE - KITCHEN / LIVING ROOM - CONTINUOUS

– and into the warmth.

A kettle ticks as it cools. Two mugs wait on the counter. One steams. One is stone cold.

MAYA, 30s, coat still on, stands at the island. Her phone lies face-down under her flat palm, pinned there. Everything about her day is finished except this.

JAMES, 30s, is at the counter with a tea towel, drying a plate. He has been drying the same plate for some time.

The camera settles a few feet off his shoulder. He doesn't look at it. But something in him eases – the small give of a body that has decided it isn't alone.

MAYA

I moved the seven o'clock.

JAMES

You didn't have to do that.

MAYA

I know I didn't have to. That's the – I rearranged my entire night so we could sit in a room and be two people, and you're doing the dishes.

JAMES

It's one plate.

MAYA
It's been one plate for twenty
minutes.

He looks at the plate like someone just put it in his hands.
Sets it down.

MAYA (CONT'D)
You made two coffees this morning.

JAMES
Did I.

MAYA
Two. I watched you. You drank one
and you poured the other one down
the sink. A full mug. And you
weren't even upset about it –
that's the part. You did it like it
was the most normal thing in the
world.

JAMES
I made too much.

MAYA
You don't make too much. You
measure the rice, James. You weigh
it. You have never once in six
years made too much of anything.

He picks up the cold mug. Slides it two inches left. Squares
it against nothing. Doesn't notice he's done it.

MAYA (CONT'D)
I've stopped asking who's coming
over.

JAMES
Nobody's coming over.

MAYA
I know. I've found the good glasses
out. I've come down to the table
set for a dinner that was the two
of us. I stopped asking because the
answer was making me feel insane,
so now I just – clock it, and I put
the extra one back in the cupboard,
and I don't say anything.

JAMES
I like the house nice.

MAYA
You like the house ready. It's a
different thing. You keep it ready
like a waiting room.

He crosses to the back door. Opens it. Cold pours in. He
props it with his heel, then his foot, then just – leaves
it. An inch. Like the window.

MAYA (CONT'D)
It's November.

JAMES
It gets close in here.

The camera drifts a slow, low arc between them. James's eyes
go with it. Not to her. To it. To the empty air where it
moves.

Maya watches him watch nothing at all.

MAYA
There. You just left.

JAMES
I'm standing right here.

MAYA
Say my name.

JAMES
What?

MAYA
Say my name. Right now. Without
looking for it first.

A beat. His head turns – a fraction, toward the space beside
him – before it comes back to her.

JAMES
Maya.

MAYA
You had to find me first.

Silence. The kettle ticks.

MAYA (CONT'D)

I used to think I could out-wait it. Whatever it is. I told myself, be patient, he's carrying something, and if I'm good enough and quiet enough and I don't make it worse, one day he'll set it down and turn around and I'll be standing there.

JAMES

Don't.

MAYA

I made myself so easy to be married to that I stopped being in the marriage. I disappeared to give you room. And the room was never for me.

JAMES

You want all of me.

MAYA

I want any of you. I'd take any of you.

JAMES

(beat)

There isn't all of me. There's what's left over. I told you that. At the start — I told you what this was, and you married what was left over, and now you're standing in my kitchen furious that it isn't more.

The words land. She doesn't flinch. That's the frightening part.

She takes her hand off the phone. Picks it up. The tell that she's done.

MAYA

I made myself smaller so there'd be room for me. Do you hear how that — I made myself smaller to fit into the space where I already was.

The wall comes down. One second. Her whole face, open, unarmed.

Then she reaches up and does a coat button that was already done. And it's back. Brick by brick, in real time — the most honest thing she does all night.

MAYA (CONT'D)

Anyway.

He crosses the room to her. Fast, for him. He lifts a hand toward her face. It's real. For one second the whole thing could stop here.

The camera slides into the edge of the frame.

His eyes flick to it. Half a second. No more.

She sees the flick.

MAYA (CONT'D)

(quiet)

No. Don't do the one where you almost.

She steps back out of his reach.

MAYA (CONT'D)

Lock the door after me. Both of them.

JAMES

Maya —

MAYA

The seven-thirty's real. I do have to go.

She doesn't. They both know she doesn't. She goes anyway.

The camera does not follow her.

It stays with James. The front door opens off-frame. A wash of cold. It clicks shut.

Silence, except the kettle, ticking down to nothing.

James stands alone in the middle of the room. His hand comes up, slow, and hangs in the air beside him — palm open, at a height, as if to rest on a shoulder that should be there.

The camera drifts into that space. Right into it. Fills the place where his hand is reaching. Warm. Familiar. Waiting to be touched.

His fingers are an inch from the lens.

And he sees it. Really sees it — sees what he's doing, sees the reach, sees the room, sees the two mugs and the extra glass and the open door and the whole shape of the evening laid out like evidence.

His face breaks.

JAMES (CONT'D)
(barely)
No.

He steps back from it.

JAMES (CONT'D)
No. Not – not now. Not tonight.

The camera follows him. Gentle. It doesn't understand. It comes closer.

JAMES (CONT'D)
(a roar, ragged, at the
empty air)
FUCK OFF!

The camera flinches.

Then it BOLTS – a hard rush back, away from him, across the room, low over the counter, past the cold mug, out through the gap in the window where it came –

EXT. SUBURBAN HOUSE - CONTINUOUS

– out into the cold and UP, fast, climbing hard, the gold window shrinking beneath it.

It stops, high above the roof, and looks down.

Down at the little lit house. Down at the one warm window with the man standing in it, small now, both hands over his face.

The camera holds there in the dark, tilted down – the way you look back at a place you have just been thrown out of.

The way an intruder looks at a house.

FADE OUT.